

of over 1 million, almost all to the US. The population of Ireland in 1841 was 6.5 million; by 1871, it had dipped to 4 million.

Urban underclass

Industrialization produced a similar paradox. Whatever the civic pride and bombast of the immense new urban centers of the Industrial Revolution, especially in Britain, a new urban underclass was being created, desperately impoverished and living in extreme squalor.

For the citizens of continental Europe, the lure of new lands in which to be free and prosper would prove irresistible. Substantial numbers of Germans, Czechs, and Hungarians left central Europe after the suppression of the nationalist revolts of 1848. From 1870, huge numbers of Russian and Polish Jews—1.5 million in 1901–1910 alone—similarly emigrated, fleeing anti-Semitic pogroms.

The numbers involved in this huge transfer of populations were remarkable. From the mid-19th century to 1924, 18 million people emigrated from Britain; 9.5 million from Italy, mostly from its deprived south; 8 million from Russia; 5 million from Austria-Hungary; and 4.5 million from Germany. Between 1820 and 1920, the US attracted 33.6 million

“I had always hoped that this land might become a safe and agreeable asylum to the virtuous and persecuted part of mankind, to whatever nation they might belong.

George Washington”

immigrants, where they often found themselves in poor living conditions in rapidly expanding cities such as Chicago and New York, aiding the growth of American industry with their cheap labor. Over the same period, 3.6 million Europeans settled in South America, and 2 million in Australia and New Zealand.

Unwelcome guests

This process of relocation was not exclusively European. Indians settled in South Africa, Chinese migrants spread across the East Indies, and Japanese migrants settled in California; many found themselves unwelcome.

By 1910, more than one in seven of the US population had been born outside of the United States. ■

Ellis Island

Opened on January 1, 1892, Ellis Island, along with the Statue of Liberty, became a symbol of the vast stream of immigrants that poured into the United States. This immigration center processed perhaps 12 million people, and it is claimed that as much as 40 percent of the immigrant population of the United States has at least one relative who was fed through this immense bureaucratic machine. Built on nothing more than a nondescript

sandy island, close to the New Jersey shore in New York Harbor, Ellis Island had at its heart a vast, echoing hall. Here, shuffling forward, the newly arrived immigrants, speaking a dazzling array of languages, would be processed. They were examined medically before being subjected to a series of simple questions to establish their eligibility. The great majority would then become accepted as citizens of the United States, with scarcely 2 percent turned away. Ellis Island finally closed its doors on November 12, 1954.



In its first 30 years, Ellis Island saw 80 percent of United States' immigrants passing through—almost 12 million people.